investigation is under way to establish the facts and identify all individuals responsible for this situation". The release went on to state that Aarthi Subramanian, COO at TCS, will lead this investigation. "Appropriate and stringent action will be taken against those found guilty. Any necessary process improvements or corrective measures will be promptly implemented and strictly enforced," it stated further.

A 'SORDID' AFFAIR

For Vaishnavi, 20 years old at the time, it had seemed like a story straight out of a romance novel: a chance meeting with Danish, her college alumnus, at the crowded Levitt market in the cantonment town of Devlali, followed by frequent catch-ups at the popular hangout of Khandoba Tekdi, a job at the same company where he was a team leader, and then... promise of marriage. This is what her FIR, registered on March 26 at Devlali Camp, states. At work, say her colleagues, Danish was an indulgent boss, allowing her privileges others were denied. If there were warning signs, she seems to have ignored them.

Or was perhaps forced to. According to her FIR, another team leader, Tausif, allegedly threatened to expose their relationship and sought sexual favours to stay silent. This pattern of abuse continued over the three years since she joined the company in 2023. The final blow came this February, when a woman—claiming to be Danish's wife—called to tell her about their marriage and two children.

But Vaishnavi does not seem to be the only one. Another FIR, for instance, cites a pattern of workplace harassment since 2023. Raza, another senior staffer, allegedly repeatedly stared, followed and attempted to touch the complainant, alongside making sexually suggestive remarks about her marriage. She has also accused another colleague, Shahrukh, of making inappropriate advances on the occasion of Gudi Padwa on March 19. A third woman, in her FIR, has accused these two of commenting on her physique and asking intrusive questions about her relationships, along with a suggestive remark implying she could be "prepared" for one of them.

The FIRs speak of religious persecution too. Vaishnavi, in her complaint, recounts how Danish and Tausif would allegedly mock her religious beliefs and repeatedly invoke the benefits of converting to Islam, and how Nida tried to convince her that the "Shivling is actually a representation of the male organ and that worshipping it is obscene". Another FIR was filed by a male employee, Krishna, in which he alleges that Tausif, along with Danish, Raza and Shahrukh, "forcibly made me wear their religious cap and recite namaaz. They would also take me along to hotels for meals and force me to eat non-vegetarian food. When I refused, they would insult me and make derogatory comments about my religion".

"The accused were in important positions," says Karnik, "so they misused their authority and position to sexually and religiously harass co-workers." A Special Investigation Team (SIT) has been formed. The National Investigation Agency and the Anti-Terrorism Squad, too, have joined the probe, and are investigating the alleged probability of a larger conversion syndicate, cross-border links with a radical preacher, and suspicious financial transactions. "We are investigating whether this happened through a local religious network, social media, or other channels involved in radicalisation," says an officer, on the condition of anonymity.

PATTERNS OF CONTROL

The modus operandi, according to investigators, followed a clear, consistent pattern. It began with grooming: an offer of trust, romance or protection. The accused would break the ice with young women colleagues by appearing to be helpful and attentive. Allegations are that they would even sabotage their scooties—disconnect wires, for instance—and then "fix" the problem or offer a ride home. If a woman did not report to work, they would allegedly call her

THE ACCUSED

Nine FIRs have been filed against eight TCS employees on charges ranging from sexual harassment to hurting religious sentiments; seven have been arrested

DANISH SHEIKH
39, Bhabha Nagar, Nashik

A team leader, allegedly lured a victim into a physical relationship under false promise of marriage

MAYUR BARGAJE



PROBE DEEPENS The accused being produced in court, Nashik, Apr. 20



"A preliminary review indicates we have not received any complaints of the nature that are being alleged.... TCS remains fully committed to the safety, dignity and well-being of every employee"

K. KRITHIVASAN
CEO & MD, TCS